

Day Trading: Adapting to Change By Asher Levine

Abstract

This study explored how extreme stock market volatility influenced the effectiveness of different short-period momentum-based day trading strategies. Financial markets across the globe are becoming more unpredictable due to economic news, war, and new technological advancements, and traders everywhere are struggling to maintain profitability. Using a correlational research design, this study analyzed the performance of multiple short-term trading strategies, including the Opening Range Breakout (ORB) and common ICT concepts, through simulated trading on TradingView's Paper trading platform with a strict focus on E-mini S&P 500 futures (ES Futures). The performance of my trading was measured from October to December by measuring profitability and win percentage under volatile conditions. Results showed an overall profitable performance with a 53% win rate, while the ORB strategy achieved a statistically significantly higher success rate of 75% compared to the other momentum continuation models. A two-proportion z-test indicated that the difference in the strategies was statistically significant, as I achieved a $z = 1.68$ and $p = 0.047$. These findings indicate that structured momentum strategies can remain effective in volatile markets but only when combined with risk management and discipline. This study contributes to existing research by focusing specifically on short-term momentum trading during periods of volatile movement and shows that traders anywhere can learn to adapt to the market.

Introduction

The stock market is constantly facing problems: unpredictable trends, uncertainty about the direction it will move towards, and rapid structural breaks, where it changes the direction it was moving in. In recent years, volatility has increased to a more significant level due to news, politics, and the broader economic landscape of the world. For instance, when President Donald Trump announced a large tariff on China, the NASDAQ and S and P 500 (both stocks that contain the top 500 largest companies) dropped dramatically in the span of seconds, causing thousands of people to lose their trades and with that large amounts of money (Pound, 2025). Price swings, algorithmic trading with new AI models that can tell you when to buy or sell, and real-time information from news stations, have changed and shaped how different institutions analyze and invest in short-term buying and selling opportunities. In this world of trading, momentum trading is defined by stocks moving in either an upward or downward trend. It will continue to move in the same direction to a certain area for a period of time, and you place a trade that moves with the trend. At the end of the trend, we see a change and break of structure (BOS), which would let us know when not to trade the previous trend. Momentum trading has become the most popular and basic strategy, according to City Index, as it states that it is the thing that traders turn to when learning about day trading, which is to understand the study of extreme market movement with trend trading (City Index, 2025).

As the market becomes more unpredictable and reactive based on the buyers and sellers in that time frame, the reliability of such short-period momentum strategies faces new

challenges. Extreme market movements, such as sudden price spikes or devastating drops, can change patterns and destroy the idea that traders can become profitable on these small movements. These conditions create important questions about whether traditional momentum techniques like the most commonly known one, ICT, inner circle trading developed by Michael Huddleston, which is a strategy that follows institutions and their previous behavior, are still functional when volatility is rapidly moving in all directions, and how traders can adapt to the market as it changes. The problem is that the market now moves so unpredictably that it no longer matches what momentum trading expects to happen.

Momentum trading strategies can also be understood through different financial theories, like the Efficient Market Hypothesis and Behavioral Finance. As described by Andrew Lo at MIT, the Efficient Market Hypothesis argues that all available information is already reflected in previous stock prices (Lo, 2007). This suggests that it is constantly outperforming the market, and strategies like momentum trading should not be possible. However, behavioral finance theory challenges this by theorizing that psychological factors like greed, fear, and rashness directly influence these decisions. In a sense, these emotional responses cause prices to trend in a specific direction for short periods at a time, which is where I looked to make my trades. This conflict between theories in this industry proves the importance of analyzing whether momentum trading strategies remain effective under volatile conditions.

With the large number of normal people who have learned about day trading through a friend or even TikTok, and look at short-term buying and selling strategies as a way to start, understanding how extreme volatility influences the way they trade and make decisions is both relevant and necessary when people's financial stakes are on the line. My study sought to evaluate how large market swings can change the effectiveness of short-period momentum trading strategies and if these momentum strategies remain consistent in these violent, harsh markets. The goal is to figure out the relationship between extreme market movement and the profitability of momentum-based decision making, offering information and strategy into the definition of these basic strategies for modern short-term traders, and how to manipulate the market in your favor.

Review of Relevant Literature

Daytrading

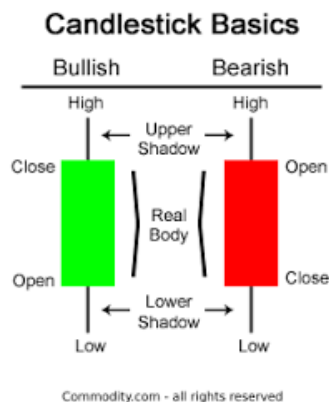
Day trading is the buying and selling of various financial assets within the same day to profit from short-term price movements. A trading day is within the same hours as the stock market is open: pre-market from 4:00 am - 9:30 am, and the actual market from 9:30 am - 4 pm for the New York session. Traders often use momentum-based strategies, where price shifts or “extreme movement” can create quick profit or sudden, horrible losses. These short periods of volatility tend to increase the chances of both risk and reward, making the time that you execute your strategy one of the most important parts of day trading. Traders must learn to understand how these intense market changes occur and how to react to them, because as traders, they must

adapt to new methods and strategies to maintain consistency and effectiveness during violent conditions while still managing their risk. Day trading provides a harsh environment in which stock market movements influence the success or failure of short-term momentum strategies.

Building on this idea, Hwang further explores the nature of day trading in “5 Day-Trading Strategies for Beginners.” She introduces day trading as buying and selling of large companies' holdings within the same trading day to profit on short-term price movement. The article talks and goes into detail about the 5 most common types of trading strategies: momentum trading, scalping, swing trading, news-based trading, and using limit or market orders, and makes it important that trading is based on the market's liquidity, how many buyers and sellers are currently active in the market, volatility, the direction and pace the market is going, and volume. Hwang also stresses the importance of risk management, telling traders to only use capital they can afford to lose due to the large amount of risk at hand, to stick to a strategy, and to avoid angry trading, as my mentor would say (Hwang, 2025). That is the most important part of trading. In all, she concludes that while day trading may offer profit opportunities, it carries high risk and demands that you stay mentally disciplined, strategic, and well-educated on the industry.

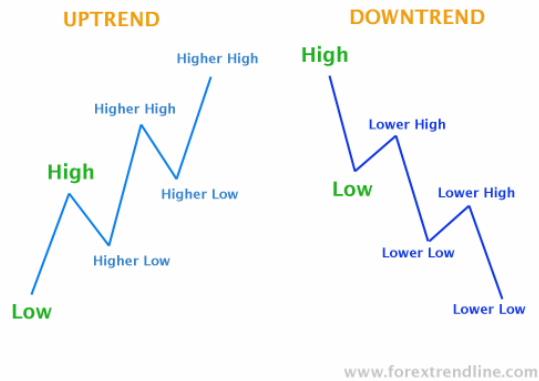
Trends and Candle Sticks

Candlestick patterns play a major role in identifying where the market is going to trend. Traders often study these formations to spot early signs of reversals, continuations, or continuations, which can indicate when to enter or exit trades. In “*How to Trade Bullish and Bearish Engulfing Candlestick Patterns*,” ThinkMarkets explains how specific patterns, particularly bullish and bearish engulfing formations, when one bullish candle is larger and holds a bearish candle within the candle, serve as indicators of price and trend changes, which we call a break of structure (ThinkMarket, 2026). Bullish candles occur when the price of a stock is increasing within the chosen time frame, while bearish candles occur when the price is decreasing.



A bullish engulfing appears when a smaller red candle is completely overtaken by a larger green one, suggesting buyers are gaining momentum, indicating that there may be an upward trend about to happen. On the other hand, a bearish engulfing forms when a smaller green candle is fully engulfed by a larger red one, hinting that sellers might take control, which would indicate a trend to the downside. ThinkMarkets also talks about how traders do not just use these to signify when to buy and sell, but they also look for other things, like volume levels and support or

resistance zones created by the chart going to an area of a large number of buyers or sellers. Risk management through stop losses or confirmation signals is just as important to prevent losing entries (ThinkMarket, 2026). Understanding these patterns and how they can align with different time frames and other indicators is what traders look for when using momentum-based trading strategies, specifically in fast-paced environments.



Risk management

Having the right discipline and smart risk management is the most crucial part of day trading, where quick decisions and intense price movements can lead to large losses, but just as easily to have big wins. Traders use strategies like stop-loss orders, position sizing, and capital limits to protect themselves and their money. D. Ryu examines whether individual day traders who are a part of large financial institutions can consistently earn a profit in the stock market. She developed her thesis by using data from the Korean stock exchange and looks at trading performance across different financial institutions, and finds that only a small fraction achieve long-term profitability, which explains the statistic where only 90% of traders are profitable, while most losses are due to having a limited amount of information or just not understanding it (Ryu, 2015). This just goes over the importance of risk management and shows that even skilled traders struggle to beat the market without a clear, controlled approach to risk. Ryu's findings highlight that success in short-term momentum trading isn't only about timing the market to get your perfect entry, but it's also about minimizing loss when extreme movement turns against a trader's initial idea.

Volatility and Liquidity

Volatility and liquidity are two of the most influential factors that traders use to decide whether they want to enter a trade or not, but they can also bring them to situations of great loss. Volatility is the speed and intensity of the price of a stock, while liquidity measures how easily assets can be bought or sold without significantly affecting their price due to the number of buyers and/or sellers in that particular market. They are very similar and go hand in hand, especially when traders are deciding whether to make a trade or not. In *"Volatility"* (FINRA, 2025), the author defined volatility as the degree to which stock prices swing up and down, noting that larger swings indicate large amounts of volatility. The article explains that long-term

investors often view these movements as temporary noise and hold through them as they largely trend in a set direction for a long period of time, like the S and P 500, as it has been in a large uptrend for the past few years. But active traders see them as opportunities for short-term profit. FINRA also emphasizes that managing risk and emotions is very important in volatile markets, recommending strategies such as setting clear goals, staying disciplined, and avoiding emotionally charged trading. High volatility combined with low liquidity can make momentum strategies unpredictable, which is a major problem in this discipline, as prices may move too quickly or be driven by irrelevant indicators, leading traders to large losses. Understanding this balance is key to learning how to trade with extreme market movements that influence the effectiveness of short-period momentum strategies.

Gap

While day trading and momentum-based strategies have been studied, much of the existing research focuses on general profitability through long-term investments, but does not go into depth on the short-term trading strategies that are based on momentum. Few studies explore how intense price movements are, such as during periods of volatility, and how they affect the success of short-period momentum strategies in trading.

There has been previous research done to explore the effectiveness of momentum-based investing strategies across different financial markets. Studies created by Narasimhan Jegadeesh and Sheridan Titman found that stocks that have performed well in the past tend to perform well in the short term (Jegadeesh, 2001). However, these studies focused primarily on longer holding periods rather than fast, short-term trading. Previously, Andrew Lo argued that, through the Efficient Market Hypothesis, such patterns should not consistently exist. Thus emphasizing the need to examine whether short-term momentum strategies remain effective in a highly volatile environment.

This gap leaves uncertainty about whether these strategies remain effective when markets move unpredictably, and how we must adapt as traders. By examining how extreme stock market movements influence short-term momentum trading performance, this research aims to provide insight into an area that current research has largely overlooked, with no clear strategy, which leads us to the question. How does the extreme movement in the stock market influence the effectiveness of short-period momentum trading strategies in short-term buying and selling of certain stocks?

Methods

Research Design

This study developed a correlational research design examining the mutual relationship between two independent variables as described by James Barra with DayTrading.com (Barra, 2025). Within this paper, it is exploring the relationship between extreme stock-market movement and how well short-term day trading strategies can be used against it is explored.

Correlational research is a non-experimental method in which researchers examine variables without manipulating them. This fits my study because of how volatile the market is, and short-term trading outcomes based on set strategies cannot be changed or controlled by the researcher or anyone. By examining how extreme stock market movements influence short-term momentum trading performance, this research aims to provide insight into an area that current research has largely overlooked. Specifically, the research investigates whether periods of extreme volatility in ES Mini Futures S&P 500 influence the success rate (win percentage) of multiple short-term momentum strategies. Michael Zarembski from Charles Schwab, one of the largest banking and investing services, describes futures as contracts that are standardized agreements to buy or sell an asset at a price on a specific date in the future, hoping that it will get to that price (Zarembski, 2025).

Participants and Materials

No human participants were used during this study. All trading was performed using TradingView's Paper Trading (Paperview) simulation platform, which allows users to explore the market and place trades with no financial risk. E-mini S&P 500 futures (ES) checks off all the boxes. Due to its high liquidity, volatility, and widespread use as a trading instrument, according to MetroTrade (MetroTrade, 2025). The tools and indicators that I used during the study were: TradingView charting platform, ES Mini Futures, NDOG EH indicator to present High-Volume Area / HVA zones, manually drawn previous-day highs and lows, and Fair Value Gap. (FVG), Inverse Fair Value Gaps, Order Blocks, and continuation models. I chose these because they are frequently used in real short-term trading and provide reliable confluences. They also help identify strategic setups during extreme volatile movement, making them ideal to use when trying to maximize short-term trading profitability.

Procedures

To start the process, turn on a laptop or a phone, open TradingView, and create an account. Trading View is a platform that allows us to monitor and trade different types of stocks, currencies, and futures. The New York market opens at 9:30 EST, but the pre-market opens at 8. In TradingView, there are different options where you can connect yourself to various brokerages. With this, we will open the Paper Trading simulation trading option, which is a simulation that allows anyone to trade real stocks without risking any personal finances. We are going to ES Mini Futures for the S&P 500 because that is the future that will be focused on in this study.

What I did was to go to the daily time frame and mark out the daily highs where the price was at its highest point, and the daily lows. On the left side of TradingView, there are different options to draw on the charts for any reason. I created a line where the price was the highest it had been and the lowest it had been on that previous day. At the top of the website, there is a button named indicator. Indicators are functions that are built on basic statistics during a trading day that is free to everyone.

In the indicators section, I searched for and turned on NDOG EH. This is an indicator that creates order blocks and HVA zones (high volume area). An order block is a significant price level where institutional traders place orders, which causes a market reaction. While HVA zones are also considered high-volume areas. In these zones, if the candlestick of the instrument hits the edge or midpoint of these zones, it causes a reversal that allows me to enter these trades. Based on these confluences (things that help us find reliability in trades), I decided whether to take a short or long position. The other strategy that I used is the 8 am to 8:15 am ORB, which stands for the opening range breakout. Tom Chen describes this strategy as an effective strategy that helps traders identify trading opportunities during the opening hour of the market, as he continues to break down the strategy (Chen 2025). When I used this strategy, I would mark out the 8 to 8:15 am candle and use the drawing tool to make a rectangle around the candle and extend it. Between 8-9:30 am, I expected to see the market break to the upside or downside, and after it did that, I waited till it moved back to the middle area of the rectangle drawn and looked to trade in continuation of the breakout direction. I always made sure my risk parameters were set so I didn't lose all of your money. In the simulation, the maximum amount of money I risked per trade was 300 dollars, which allowed me to meet profit projections while not risking drawdown breaches, where I could lose significant amounts.

When trading, I constantly watched the trade. If it is moving towards my take profit, once it reaches a bit over halfway towards my take profit, I set my stop loss to break even, so I don't lose any money on the trade. Or when I saw the trend was starting to change direction, I would close out of the trade completely, so I don't end up getting stopped out. This allowed me to be risk-free in a market where 98% of people fail. If moving towards stop loss, and showing no signs of reversing, I can close out early so I don't lose the maximum amount of money I was willing to risk. I could also let it play through and hit my stop loss, hoping that it will move back up to where you are in profit.

Trading is not about fast cash; it is a process that takes time, which is the biggest limitation within this project, and is something that I must monitor thoroughly to make sure my project can be done. Patience and, most importantly, strict discipline are two of the most crucial variables when becoming a trader. I took multiple trades over time, but only trades with good setups. The one thing that causes most traders to lose money is trading based on emotion or greed.

Results

Analysis

In the world of stocks and trading, the markets are constantly changing with extreme volatility and momentum. Finding a way to become profitable while still having a strong win percentage is difficult. This research is defended because the purpose of my study is to analyze various short-term day-trading strategies to determine whether I can achieve profitability while

maintaining a win rate over 50%. Using the different strategies, my original hypothesis of achieving profitability was met with a 53% win rate over the trades I took from October to December.

Statistical Test

When analyzing the different strategies, the ORB strategy achieved a win rate of 75%, compared to 52.5% for the continuation model strategy. I then compared the two by creating a two-proportion z-test, which indicated that this difference was statistically significant ($z = 1.68$, $p = 0.047$), proving that the ORB strategy produced a higher amount of winning trades.

The win rates were obtained by dividing the number of winning trades by the total number of trades for both the ORB and the continuation model strategies. The null hypothesis stated that both win rates were at 50%, so a pooled proportion was calculated by combining wins and trades from both strategies. This value was then used to calculate the standard error of the difference in proportions. The z-statistic was calculated by dividing the difference between the win rates of the two strategies by this standard error, and a one-tailed p-value was computed to assess whether the ORB strategy's win rate was significantly higher than the continuation model's.

The higher win rate that was observed by the ORB momentum strategy can be explained by the market structure during the opening period of the day. The first hour of trading typically contains the largest amounts of liquidity and people in the market, which is when institutional investors and large firms are placing their trades. Due to the fluctuation of volume, it often leads to clearer directional price movement and reliable breakout patterns, where price action is static and influenced by normal people. As a result, the ORB strategy benefits from the initial momentum from the first move of the day, which defends what made this strategy the most profitable within the time I used to make my trades.

Formulas

These were the formulas I used when conducting the test. The significance level used was $\alpha=0.05$

x_1 =number of winning trades, n_1 =total trades for strategy 1

Sample proportions: $\hat{p}_1 = x_1 / n_1$ and $\hat{p}_2 = x_2 / n_2$

Pooled Proportions $\hat{p} = (x_1 + x_2) / (n_1 + n_2)$

Standard Error: $SE = \sqrt{\hat{p}(1 - \hat{p})(1/n_1 + 1/n_2)}$

Z Statistic: $z = (\hat{p}_1 - \hat{p}_2) / SE$

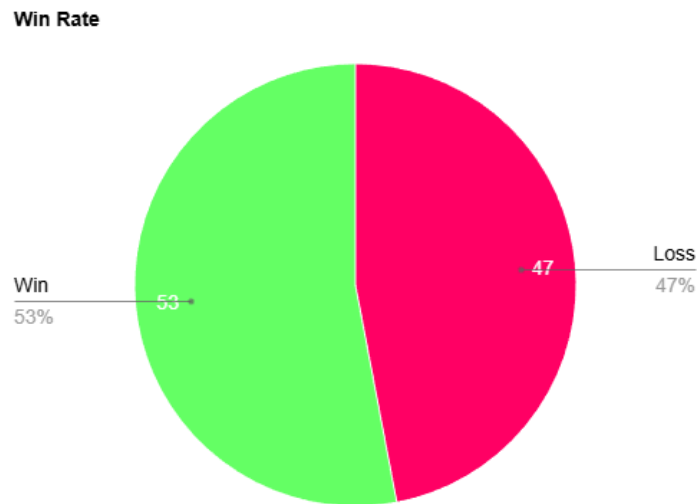
P Value: $p = P(Z > z)$

Data

Figure 1: Data Table

Win Rate ▾  				
Tt	Win ▾	Loss ▾	Date ▾	Trade W/L ▾
1266+		-200	Oct 20, 2025	2/1
1002+		-200	Oct 21, 2025	1/1
1400+		-300	Oct 22, 2025	2/1
1865+		-500	Oct 23, 2025	2/2
2400+		0	Oct 27, 2025	2/0
2041+		-300	Oct 28, 2025	2/1
2100+		-300	Oct 29, 2025	2/1
3202+		-600	Oct 30, 2025	3/2
1936+		-260	Oct 31, 2025	2/1
1506+		-300	Nov 3, 2025	2/1
2100+		-150	Nov 4, 2025	2/1
3713+		0	Nov 5, 2025	3/0
800+		-500	Nov 6, 2025	1/2
1200+		-300	Nov 10, 2025	2/1
700+		0	Nov 11, 2025	1/0
0		-300	Nov 12, 2025	0/1
1300+		-300	Nov 13, 2025	2/1
2000		-150	Nov 14, 2025	2/1
300+		-300	Nov 17, 2025	1/1
1760+		0	Nov 19, 2025	2/0
1700+		-400	Nov 20, 2025	2/1
900+		0	Nov 26, 2025	1/0
0		-600	Dec 1, 2025	0/2

This data table represents all of the data used to calculate the win percentage. Each day that I made a certain number of trades, I kept and documented them in this Google sheet so I could understand how my strategies were performing each day and calculate a win rate. On the very left, it shows the amount of money I won while paper trading on that day, while the value directly to the right shows how much I lost. Each row contains all of the data gathered within a single trading day, while the very last column describes the number of winning trades compared to losing trades per day.

Figure 2: Win Rate Pie Chart

Created using piechartmaker.co

This pie chart, which was created on Piechartmaker.co, describes the win rate based on my strategy and entry models used. It was found by calculating the win rate by dividing the total amount of wins by the total number of trades. As shown, it shows that based on the strategy I used, as well as having proper risk management, it allowed for a 53% win rate. This was within 5% of my hypothesized win percentage, which allows for a trader to have a positive win rate of over 50% while still making a profit from their trades.

Conclusion

Discussion

The purpose of this study was to analyze the volatility in the stock market. To further this project, we used short-term day trading strategies so that I could achieve profitability while maintaining a win rate over 50%. When first starting to trade, I focused on common trend trading and ICT concepts. While the trades made from that did prove profitability one strategy stood out.

The most notable thing when conducting this project was the usefulness of the 8-8:15 ORB strategy. This proved to achieve a 73% win rate while generating money at a profitable scale. FINRA's definition of volatility was extremely important in my work, as volatility was what we were watching and reading reactions to. This was shown by conducting a one-tailed t-test to test significance. Because we had an alpha level of .05 and the p-value of the ORB strategy compared to common ICT strategies gave us a p-value of .047, stating that the ORB strategy was statistically significant. With this, it proves that even when the market is volatile and out of control, if you follow your rules and your strategy, you have the chance at becoming profitable in trading.

Limitations

Trading is completely unpredictable. No matter what strategy you have, the market is out of an individual's control and can move up and down at any second. No strategies will have a 100% win rate, this is because the market is always moving and, more importantly, always changing. One limitation that is commonly prevalent in trading is the human mind. Day trading brings many mental battles with yourself. Not many people can lose large amounts of money at a time and be happy with the outcome. That is another reason why trading is brilliant: it allows you to work against your mind and build strict discipline, patience, and even anger management. A limitation that was prevalent in my work was the news. During December specifically, the stock market was all over the place and ended up projecting horrible price movement as Vlad Karpel describes it, some of the worst monthly performances in years, where the S&P 500 dropped 1.5% as well as NASDAQ with -1.7% (Karpel 2024). When being put in situations like this, you must understand that you do not need to trade every day, but as I said before, build the discipline that is needed to win.

Another limitation of this study was the use of a paper trading simulation. This does not fully replicate the psychological problems and pressures that come with real money, which can change the effectiveness of the strategies I tested. Additionally, the relatively small sample size of trades limited to only myself limits the generalization of the findings. A larger data set across a longer period of time that includes different market conditions would have provided a more reliable conclusion regarding the effectiveness.

Implications

Although the results gained from my study prove profitability through structured momentum-based strategies, it is extremely important to understand that consistent profitability in trading is undeniably hard to achieve. The previous research explains that the majority of traders fail long-term due to improper risk management, emotional decision-making, and a lack of discipline when presented with large amounts of money. Therefore, as this study demonstrated profitability, success depends on yourself and your ability to maintain a strong mentality, and a good

Future Research

This research presents a new type of methodology for short-term trading. First, future researchers can continue to build on these results by examining the different strategies more deeply, thereby enabling greater generalizability and a deeper understanding of the observed patterns. Another way to further this research is to create an AI that follows your strategy and makes trades accordingly, which could help determine whether the relationships identified here remain consistent under more or less volatile conditions. Through this, trading while excluding the emotional aspect of the practice becomes a product that can revolutionize trading forever. This study offers the expansion of trading, as stated many times, the market is always moving, so you must adapt your strategy to the change. In all, this not only addresses the original research

question but also contributes data and statistics about specific strategies to existing information, creating a base for future research that can further expand and focus on understanding the many possibilities of this field.

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